

Schooling Options

prc-schooling-options

Engagement with World · Schooling · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Reached by general principle, not by a naming word
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

Public schooling, Christian schooling, and homeschooling are all permissible Christian approaches; parental responsibility for discipleship remains primary regardless.

In plain language

The two anchor passages speak with clarity about who is responsible for teaching children, and with silence about the schooling institutions the question lists. In Deuteronomy 6:6 to 9 the words are first to rest on the parent's own heart, then to be taught diligently to the sons (the verb 'sharpen into' or shanan in Hebrew), spoken about while sitting, walking, lying down, and rising up, and written on the doorposts ('doorposts' or mezuzot in Hebrew) and gates of the home. The verbs carry the weight of command, repetition, and household saturation. In Ephesians 6:4 fathers ('fathers' or pateres in Greek) are told to 'nurture' (the verb ektrepho in Greek) their children in the 'training' (paideia) and 'admonition' (nouthesia) of the Lord and not to provoke them to anger. Across both Testaments the burden of discipleship rests squarely on the parent, and that first half of the proposition, parental responsibility remaining primary, is well supported by the words themselves. The second half is different in kind. The training vocabulary in these passages names a content, training and admonition of the Lord, and a disposition, sharpened into the children, nurtured like one's own flesh, but it does not name a delivery channel. Public schooling, Christian schooling, and homeschooling are categories the canon does not put into words. Reinforcing this, the same Greek root paideia (translated 'training') appears in Acts 7:22 when Stephen says Moses was instructed in all the wisdom of the Egyptians, an entirely non-covenant setting, and Daniel was taught Chaldean letters in a pagan court yet remained faithful. So the words do not channel-restrict their own training vocabulary. Yet the household saturation of Deuteronomy 6 leads some readers to judge that any arrangement that structurally displaces parental discipleship is in tension with the texts. Because the duty is firm and the channel is genuinely underdetermined (not settled by the words) by the vocabulary, the compound statement as a whole is best treated as lexically contested rather than settled. The words decide the question of who must disciple, and they leave the question of which institutional arrangement is acceptable to wisdom rather than to direct command.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1121	בן	ben	son	4,929
H1696	דבר	dabar	to speak	1,142
H2596	חנך	chanak	to dedicate	5
H2903	טפחות	tophaphah	phylacteries	
H3789	כתב	katav	to write	211
H3824	לבב	levav	heart	233
H4201	מזוזה	mezuzah	doorpost	19

H6680	צוּ,	tsavah	to command	472
H8150	שָׁנַן,	shanan	to sharpen	6
G1625	ἐκτρέφω	ektrepheo	to nourish/rear	2
G3559	νουθεσία	nouthesia	admonition	3
G3809	παιδεία	paideia	discipline	6
G3811	παιδεύω	paideuo	to instruct	13
G3949	παροργίζω	parorgizo	to anger	2
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	426
G5043	τέκνον	teknon	child	102

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The anchor texts use command, repetition, writing, and nurture verbs that bind the parent to the discipleship task across the entire daily cycle, so the primacy clause is lexically firm. The institutional clause is different in kind. The Hebrew and Greek vocabulary names a content of teaching, namely 'training' (paideia) and 'admonition' (nouthesia) of the Lord, and a disposition, namely 'sharpen into' (shinanta) and 'nurture' (ektrepheite), but never names a delivery channel that the modern terms public, Christian, or home schooling would translate. The proposition therefore conjoins one part the lexicon decides and one part the lexicon underdetermines (the words do not settle it), and that asymmetry is itself the reason readers divide.

Scripture

Deut.6.7 · for · genre: law · figures: merism

Key terms. H8150 שָׁנַן, H1696 דִּבַּר, H1121 בֵּן:

Reasoning. The piel (the Hebrew intensive form) verb 'you shall sharpen into' or 'teach diligently' (shinanta) is directed 'to your sons' (le-vaneka) and is paired with 'you shall speak' (dibbarta), then anchored to the daily cycle of sitting in the house, walking in the way, lying down, and rising up. The cycle names every quotidian (everyday) frame by a merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) but no formal setting. The verb 'sharpen' (shanan) elsewhere refers to sharpening arrows or tongues, so its teaching sense is local to this construction and depends on the 'b' preposition object plus the human recipient, not on any named institution.

Deut.6.6 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H6680 צוּ, H3824 לֵב.

Reasoning. The commanded words are first to rest 'upon your own heart' (al-levavekha) before being transmitted, so the lexical sequence makes the parent the prior bearer of the content. The piel (the Hebrew intensive form) verb 'command' (tsavah) marks this as command, not advice, but the command targets the heart and mouth of the parent, not any delivery structure for the children.

Deut.6.9 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3789 כָּתַב, H4201 מְזוּזָה,

Reasoning. Writing the words ('and you shall write them', u-khtavtam) on the doorposts ('doorposts', mezuzot) and gates extends the teaching into the physical household. The locus is 'house' (bayit), the home, plus its 'gates' (shearim). The home and its threshold are the only spatial anchors named. Whether complementary instruction occurs elsewhere is not addressed by the words.

Eph.6.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1625 ἐκτρέφω, G3809 παιδεία, G3559 νοουθεσία, G3962 πατήρ

Reasoning. 'The fathers' (hoi pateres) are told 'nurture them' (ektrephete auta) 'in training and admonition of the Lord' (en paideia kai nouthesia kyriou). The verb 'nurture' (ektrepho) occurs only here and in Ephesians 5:29 of nourishing one's own flesh, so it is a body-care metaphor for parental sustenance, not a school-procurement verb. 'Training' (paideia) and 'admonition' (nouthesia) name the content and disposition, training and admonition of the Lord, in a possessive genitive (a noun in the 'belonging-to-X' grammatical form) that fixes the aim. The clause specifies WHAT the children must be reared in, not WHERE or BY WHOM it must be delivered.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Deut.6.6	Deut.11.18	tsk	1
Deut.6.9	Deut.11.20	tsk	1
Eph.6.4	Gen.18.19	tsk	1
Deut.6.7	Deut.6.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.7.22 · addressed

Stephen says Moses 'was instructed' (epaideuthe) 'in all the wisdom of the Egyptians' (en pase sophia Aigyption), using the exact cognate 'instruct' (paideuo) of the noun 'training' (paideia) in Ephesians 6:4. The same lexical root names instruction received inside a wholly non-covenant institution and the narrative voice attaches no rebuke. This shows that the canon's training vocabulary itself is not channel-restricted at the word level. It does not by itself prescribe permissibility of every modern channel, but it is a real lexical counterweight to any reading that would forbid non-covenant settings purely from the words 'training' (paideia) or 'instruct' (paideuo).

Dan.1.4 · addressed

Daniel and his companions were taught the literature and language of the Chaldeans inside a pagan court for three years and remained faithful while refusing defilement at the diet level. The narrative shows a faithful outcome from instruction outside the covenant home, supporting permissibility of mixed settings, but as narrative it describes and does not prescribe. The parental-primacy duty is neither delegated nor abolished by the account.

Prov.22.6 · addressed

'Train up a child' uses 'train' or 'dedicate' (chanak), a verb that elsewhere names dedicating a house or temple (1 Kings 8:63, 2 Chronicles 7:5, Deuteronomy 20:5), so its core sense is initiate or dedicate. With 'the young one' (na-ar) as object and 'according to his way' (al-pi darko) as direction, it commands a parental dedicating into a way of life. It bears on formation but its vocabulary names neither home, synagogue, nor academy, so it cannot rank the three modern modes. It is lexically silent on the disputed point and is therefore left open.

Concordance traversed

H6680, H8150, H1696, H3789, H3824, H1121, H4201, H2903, H2596, G3809, G3559, G1625, G3949, G3962, G5043, G3811

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The bundle reports no variant units and marks the cited verses outside ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope. Deuteronomy is Hebrew Old Testament and Ephesians 6:4 is textually stable for 'training' (paideia), 'admonition' (nouthesia), and 'nurture' (ektrepho), so no variant bears on the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, two_kingdoms, dispensationalism, household_centered_pedagogy

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

argument_from_silence_permissive: true · The training vocabulary in the anchor texts names content and disposition rather than channel, the cognate 'instruct' (paideuo) describes Moses receiving Egyptian instruction without rebuke, and Daniel learning Chaldean letters yielded a faithful outcome. On this reading the lexicon binds parents to the goal and leaves the channel to wisdom, so all three modern modes are permissible when parental primacy is preserved.

covenantal_formation_restrictive: disputed · The household saturation of Deuteronomy 6:6 to 9, where the words rest on the parent's heart, are sharpened into the sons, and are written on the doorposts of 'house' (bayit) and 'gates' (shearim), frames discipleship as parent-and-home centered. On this reading channels that structurally displace the parent from the bulk of formation stand in tension with the texts, so blanket equal permissibility is not lexically guaranteed even though no single mode is named or banned.

wisdom_application_neutral: disputed · Because the canon's vocabulary supplies an undisputed duty and an underdetermined (not settled by the words) channel, the proposition functions as a wisdom question rather than a lexical question. Both the permissive and the restrictive lens are reading from outside the word list, so neither can claim the words decide it.

The first clause, parental primacy, is supported across law and epistle by command, repetition, writing, and nurture verbs. The second clause, equal permissibility of three modern schooling modes, is an inference because the modes are anachronistic to the canon and the training vocabulary names content not channel.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture commands parents to disciple their children. Whether public schooling, Christian schooling, and homeschooling are each acceptable means of fulfilling that duty is the question under examination, with parental responsibility for discipleship remaining primary.

The original stem asserts that all three modes are permissible Christian approaches, which front-loads a verdict on the disputed permissibility clause. The verdict is derived on the original compound stem, but the neutralized form separates the strongly supported primacy duty from the contested channel question. (VERDICT-CHANGED: not applicable here; verdict remains 'disputed'.)

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.6.7
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.6.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8150
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2596
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1625
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3811
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.6.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Eph.6.4
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Deut.6.7

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed